RESEARCH & PLANNING

StoryCast

An accessible microsite for video and audio stories from young Rwandans · Aime Ndayambaje · October 2026

1. The problem

Young Rwandans are building companies, disability-rights networks and education projects, and many of them have already told their stories on video. But those videos are scattered across YouTube channels and conference archives, and many are hard to follow. Auto-captions mangle names and places ("Ronda" for Rwanda, "Caliphate knees" for Cali Fitness), some videos have no captions at all, and none of them come with a readable transcript.

That shuts out people who are Deaf or hard of hearing, people on slow or expensive mobile data who cannot stream video, people who prefer to read, and people using keyboards or screen readers.

Goal: a small, fast microsite that gathers these stories in one place and makes each one fully followable without needing to hear or even load the video.

2. Who it is for

User	Need	What the design does
Deaf or hard-of-hearing viewer	Know exactly what is said	Captions on by default; full, corrected transcript on every story page
Student on limited mobile data	Get the story without streaming video	Transcript readable without the video; .txt download; lightweight pages; video only loads on demand
Keyboard or screen-reader user	Reach and operate everything	Skip link, landmarks, one link per card, labelled buttons, visible focus
Teacher or researcher	Quote or reuse a passage	Timestamped transcript; click a time to jump; credit and source link
Young Rwandan with a story	Know how to take part	"How you can take part" section and contact on the About page

3. Content research

I searched for short videos where young Rwandans speak in their own words about something they are building. Three were chosen to cover different fields:

- **Bahati Satir**: a social entrepreneur setting up a youth-with-disabilities network (PinedaFoundation, 2012). Featured, because it connects directly to the site's accessibility

mission.

- **Yvan Munyengango**: how a personal trainer took over Cali Fitness in Kigali (theoisback, 2020).
- **Vanessa Mutesi**: Miss Geek Rwanda 2015 winner, with an online school idea (ITU Telecom World 2015).

Rights: these videos are under the standard YouTube licence, so they are **embedded** with YouTube's player (the reuse method YouTube allows) rather than downloaded. Each one is credited and linked to its source. StoryCast's own contribution is the cleaned-up transcript.

Transcript findings: YouTube auto-captions were the starting point, and all three needed manual correction of names, places and organisations. One candidate video had no captions at all and was replaced. This confirmed that a human-checked transcript adds real value.

Native media: a 30-second "Welcome to StoryCast" intro was produced for the project (computer-narrated), so the site also uses native `<video>` with a WebVTT `<track>`, and `<audio>`.

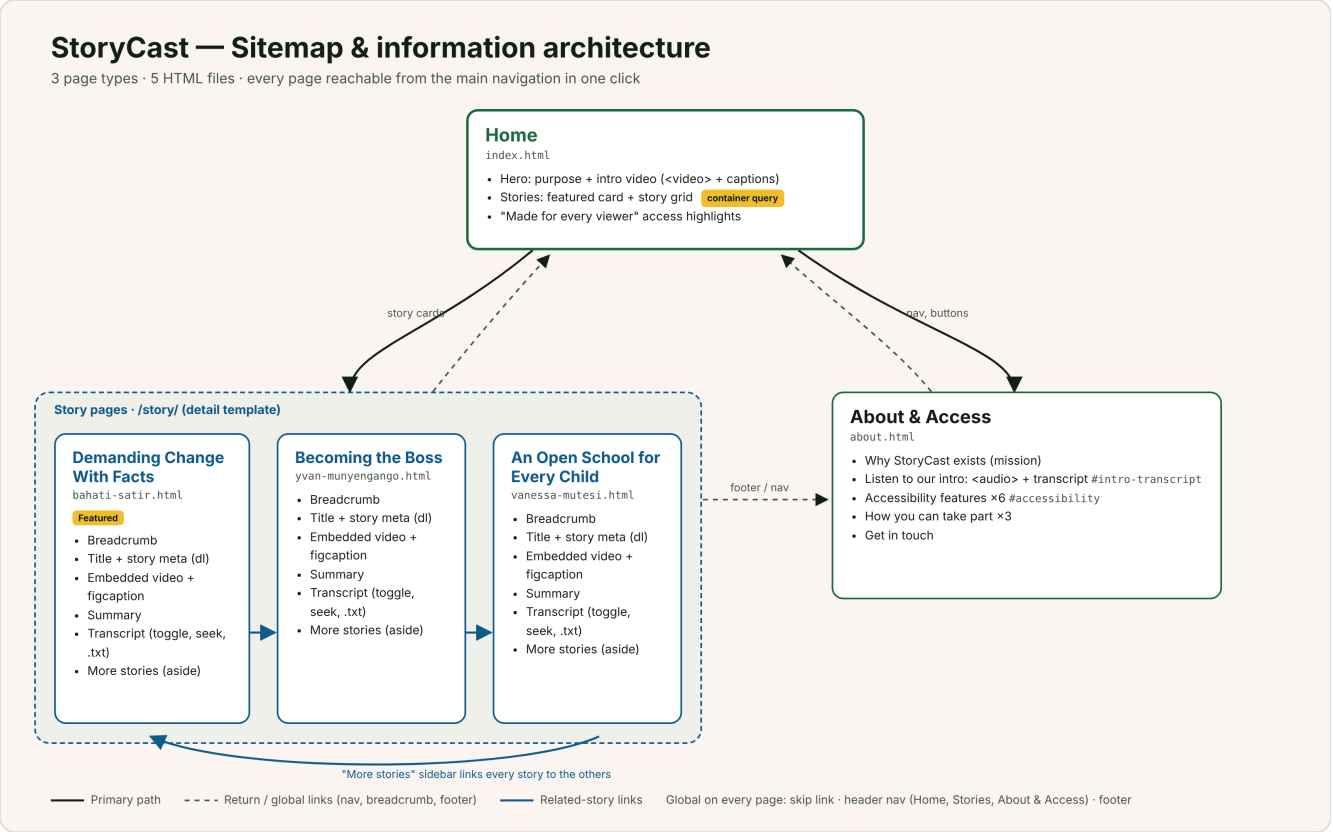
4. Accessibility research

The target is WCAG 2.1 level AA. These are the success criteria that shaped the design:

WCAG 2.1	Requirement	Design response
1.2.1 · 1.2.3 (A)	Alternative for pre-recorded audio and video	Full transcript for every story and the audio intro
1.2.2 (A)	Captions for pre-recorded video	WebVTT `<track>` on the intro; embeds load with captions on
1.3.1 (A)	Info and relationships	Landmarks, heading hierarchy, `dl` for metadata, `figure` / `figcaption`
1.4.3 (AA)	Contrast at least 4.5:1	Palette checked before design; lowest text pair is 5.6:1
1.4.10 (AA)	Reflow at 320px	Mobile-first layout; no horizontal scrolling
2.1.1 (A)	Keyboard operable	Native buttons and links only; Escape closes the menu
2.4.1 (A)	Bypass blocks	Skip link is the first element on every page
2.4.7 (AA)	Focus visible	3px sky-blue focus ring everywhere; yellow on the dark footer
4.1.2 (A)	Name, role, value	`aria-expanded` on toggles; labelled timestamp buttons; titled iframes

5. Information architecture

Three page types and five files. The hierarchy is deliberately shallow: every page is one click from the main navigation, and every story is one click from every other story.



Sitemap: pages, their content hierarchy, and how they connect.

Content hierarchy (priority order)

Home

1. What StoryCast is (H1 + intro)
2. Intro video with captions
3. Stories: featured first, then the grid
4. Accessibility highlights → About

About & Access

1. Mission
2. Audio intro + transcript
3. Accessibility features (#accessibility)
4. How to take part
5. Contact

Story (template)

1. Breadcrumb (where am I?)
2. Title, summary, storyteller facts
3. Video with credit
4. Context paragraphs
5. Transcript (show/hide, seek, download)
6. More stories

Navigation model

- Global: skip link, header nav, footer
- Local: breadcrumb, "More stories"
- Cross-links: home cards → stories; accessibility links → About#accessibility

6. Design decisions

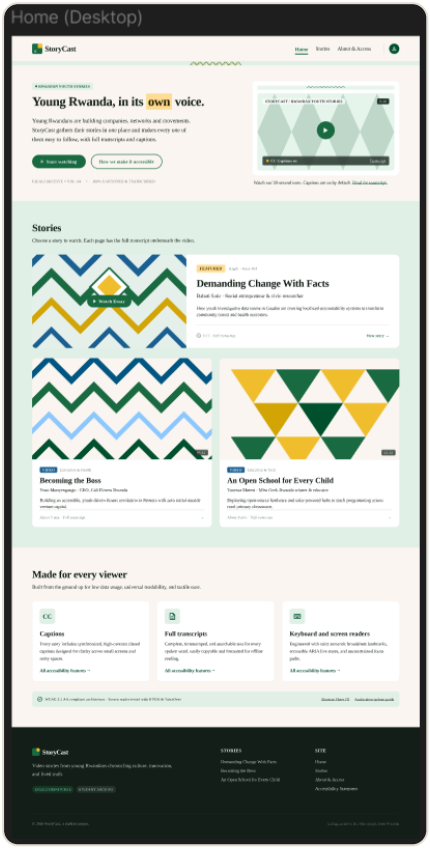
Paper	Ink	Muted	Green	Sky	Sun	Tint
#FAF7F0	#14201A	#4A5850	#1B6B45	#0F5D8C	#F2C230	#E8F1EC

- **Colour:** taken from the Rwandan flag (sky blue, sun yellow, green) on a warm paper background, instead of a dark "media player" look. Yellow fails contrast as text, so it is only ever used *behind* dark text (10:1).
- **Pattern:** card thumbnails use a geometric pattern inspired by *imigongo*, the traditional Rwandan art form. It is decorative and hidden from screen readers.
- **Type:** Bricolage Grotesque for headings (friendly, editorial), Source Sans 3 for reading (clear at small sizes), IBM Plex Mono for timestamps (aligned and scannable).
- **Transcript first:** the transcript sits on the page, not behind a download, and its timestamps are buttons that jump the video. This turns an accessibility feature into a navigation feature for everyone.
- **One responsive card:** a single media card adapts to its container: horizontal when featured, stacked in the grid, compact in the sidebar. One component, three contexts.

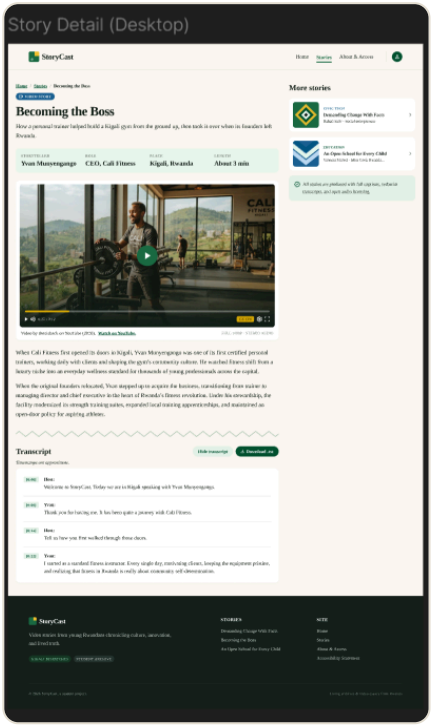
7. Wireframes & high-fidelity mockups

Low-fidelity wireframes set the layout and content order for all three pages (desktop and mobile). High-fidelity mockups then applied the colour, type and component styles above.

- **Wireframes:** https://www.figma.com/design/587MESOtmNrJcDWyv2U0uX/StoryCast?node-id=5-5474
- **High-fidelity mockups:** https://www.figma.com/design/587MESOtmNrJcDWyv2U0uX/StoryCast?node-id=0-1



Home (desktop)



Story detail (desktop)



About & Access (desktop)

High-fidelity mockups (desktop). Mobile versions and wireframes are in the Figma file.